



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

Ryan Fernando



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The impact of menstrual cycle on female athletes

Understanding the impact of the menstrual cycle on performance is crucial for providing **meaningful support** to female athletes.

Unlike male athletes, whose bodies follow a stable, daily rhythm, women navigate a complex, fluctuating hormonal landscape over the course of a month.

These natural changes can influence everything from energy levels to endurance, mood, and even pain tolerance. For many of the athletes I work with, this unpredictability presents real challenges, especially in high-stakes sports like cricket. They've shared their struggles with unbearable cramps, overwhelming fatigue, and mood swings that make even the simplest tasks feel like climbing a mountain. Yet, they push through, often resorting to painkillers while silently battling deeper fears — the possibility of menstrual leakage during a match, staining their uniforms in front of an audience, etc. This can be paralysing and distracting, undermining their focus and performance when they need it the most. On top of this mental strain, physical symptoms such as bloating or cramps can sap their stamina and endurance, making it an uphill battle just to stay in the game. Often, women follow generic fitness and diet plans without considering the fluctuations in hormones that affect energy levels, endurance, pain

tolerance, and mood throughout the month. By tailoring workouts and nutrition to different phases of the menstrual cycle, women can enhance their performance, improve recovery, and achieve better results. It is time to embrace cycle-based training and eating as a fundamental approach to women's health and fitness.

Impact on athletic performance

1. Menstrual Phase (Days 1-5):

During this time, I often notice athletes feel more fatigued and struggle with endurance due to low hormone levels. I recommend focusing on recovery with lighter workouts and ensuring they eat iron-rich foods like spinach and magnesium-rich nuts to support energy levels.

2. Follicular Phase (Days 6-14): As oestrogen rises, I see a noticeable increase in energy and focus. This is when I encourage high-intensity training and strength-building. I always advise fuelling these sessions with complex carbs like quinoa and sweet potatoes, and adding plenty of protein to aid recovery.

3. Ovulatory Phase (Days 15-17): Energy and performance peak here. I have found this phase to be the best time for athletes to push through high-intensity, power-based exercises

or competitions. I suggest meals rich in lean proteins and healthy fats to sustain this energy.

4. Luteal Phase (Days 18-28): With the rise in progesterone, athletes often report feeling more fatigued and moodier. I recommend scaling back to moderate-intensity workouts and including more recovery days. Foods rich in magnesium and Omega-3s, like nuts and fatty fish, help manage inflammation and muscle function during this phase.

Managing nutrient deficiencies

In my experience, managing nutrient intake is crucial for athletes, especially during the menstrual cycle when deficiencies can impact performance.

1. Iron and Magnesium: I often see female athletes becoming iron-deficient during menstruation, which can limit oxygen delivery to muscles, leading to fatigue and decreased endurance. Magnesium, vital for muscle function, is also depleted during this phase. To support recovery and maintain energy, I recommend supplementing with iron and magnesium during menstruation.

🌱 **Iron-rich foods:** Spinach, lean meats, fortified cereals (best absorbed with Vitamin C).